Highlights from an astronomy problem for Lagrange's equations: the Lagrange points

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These notes are appropriate for folks who have read Taylor, *Classical Mechanics* [1], Sections 7.1, 7.3, 7.5, 7.6 and 7.8, and are intended to add a bit more astronomy to the curriculum. We cover the restricted three-body problem as it relates to Lagrange points (similar to Murray and Dermott [2], Chapter 3; Goldstein, Poole and Safko [3], Section 3.12). This is the first section of a longer handout whose second half examines cosmic red shift and Hubble drag for a particle in an expanding universe, following Peebles [4], Chapter II; the full version is on GitHub.[1] We restrict ourselves to Newtonian physics throughout, though we do make reference to general relativity when it might add more depth.

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[1] https://github.com/mglerner/ClassicalMechanics/tree/main/Lagrangian/AstroLagrangeHandout

1 The Lagrange points

This section follows Taylor's Chapter 7 procedure, similar to Examples 7.4–7.7 and the recipe in Section 7.5: set the problem up, write the Lagrangian with nothing left out, state the constraints, write the Lagrangian with the constraints taken into account, find Lagrange's equations, read off what they say.

The problem. JWST sits about 1.5×10^6 km from Earth, on the far side from the Sun, at the point called L_2; Jupiter's Trojan asteroids cluster 60° ahead of and behind the planet, at L_4 and L_5 (the Greek camp ahead at L_4, the Trojan camp behind at L_5; "Trojans" is also the collective name for both). Lagrange found these five points in 1772 as special solutions of the three-body problem (the first of them, 588 Achilles, in the Greek camp, was not seen until 1906). In what sense is a point "at rest" when the Sun, the Earth and the point are all orbiting? In the frame that rotates with the two big bodies. Taylor does rotating frames with vectors in Chapter 9; here the same physics drops out of a Lagrangian in three lines, by the time-dependent coordinate change of Section 7.5.

The idea in one paragraph. The inertial coordinates (X, Y) are the ordinary, time-independent ones; the trouble is that, in them, the Lagrangian depends explicitly on t, because the primaries move and so $U(X, Y, t)$ changes in time. That means that neither of Chapter 7's tests (an ignorable coordinate, Section 7.6; no explicit t, Section 7.8) finds a conserved quantity. So, we change to rotating coordinates (x, y), which are themselves time-dependent functions of (X, Y), the kind of generalized coordinate Section 7.3 allows and Example 7.6's spinning hoop uses. In them the primaries sit still, so $U(x, y)$ has no t, and the Hamiltonian is conserved. This Hamiltonian is important enough that it gets its own name, the Jacobi integral.[2] The price of time-dependent coordinates is that they are not "natural" (Section 7.3), so T picks up terms linear in the velocities and a velocity-free term ... and, again, the conserved $\mathcal{H}$ is not $T+U$ (Section 7.8). The cosmological redshift problem (the full handout's second half) is the mirror image: the comoving coordinate $x = r/a(t)$ is also a time-dependent change, and it makes x ignorable, but t survives in $\mathcal{L}$ through $a(t)$, so there the Hamiltonian is not conserved.

The key result we will derive is

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) + m\Omega\,(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2 + y^2) - U(x, y)} \tag{1.1}$$

with U the ordinary gravitational potential energy of m in the field of the two fixed primaries, and three things follow:

- Lagrange's equations are Newton's second law plus two extra forces, the centrifugal force $m\Omega^2(x, y)$ and the Coriolis force $2m\Omega(\dot{y}, -\dot{x})$: Chapter 9's results, for free.
- A body can sit still in the rotating frame exactly where the *effective potential* $U_{\text{eff}} \equiv U - \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2 + y^2)$ has zero gradient. There are five such points (Nailing down details shows why there are exactly five). Two of them, L_4 and L_5, form equilateral triangles with M_1 and M_2, for any mass ratio; the other three lie on the line through the primaries.
- $\mathcal{L}$ has no explicit t, so $\mathcal{H}$ is conserved. It is $\tfrac{1}{2}mv_{\text{rot}}^2 + U_{\text{eff}}$ (with $v_{\text{rot}}^2 = \dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2$, the speed squared in the rotating frame), called the *Jacobi integral*, and it is *not* $T + U$. It is the only known conserved quantity for the restricted three-body problem.

[2] Named after C. G. J. Jacobi; see more in [5].

Step 1: set up the problem. Two bodies M_1 and M_2 (typically called "the primaries"), a distance R apart, go around their center of mass (CM) in circles at angular speed Ω; a third body of mass m moves in their gravity. Put the origin at the CM and use inertial Cartesian coordinates (X, Y, Z) with the primaries' orbit in the plane $Z = 0$. "Origin at the CM" means $M_1\,\mathbf{r}_1 + M_2\,\mathbf{r}_2 = 0$, i.e. $M_1 r_1 = M_2 r_2$ with $r_1 = |\,\mathbf{r}_1|$ and $r_2 = |\,\mathbf{r}_2|$, the two bodies on opposite sides of the CM. The sum of the two distances is $r_1 + r_2 = R$. Put $r_2 = R - r_1$ into $M_1 r_1 = M_2 r_2$:

$$\begin{aligned} M_1 r_1 &= M_2(R - r_1) \\ (M_1 + M_2)\, r_1 &= M_2 R && \text{(the } M_2 r_1 \text{ moved to the left)} \\ r_1 &= \frac{M_2 R}{M_1 + M_2}, && \text{and likewise} \quad r_2 = \frac{M_1 R}{M_1 + M_2}. \end{aligned} \tag{1.2}$$

It will be handy to have a name for the mass ratio: with $\mu \equiv M_2/(M_1 + M_2)$, these are $r_1 = \mu R$ and $r_2 = (1 - \mu)R$, since $M_1/(M_1 + M_2) = 1 - \mu$. For the Sun and the Earth $\mu = 3.00 \times 10^{-6}$; for the Earth and the Moon, 0.0122. Each primary goes around the CM on a circle of its own radius, r_1 or r_2, at the common angular speed Ω, so its polar angle is Ωt plus a constant; choose $t = 0$ when M_2 is on the positive X axis, so M_2's angle is Ωt, and M_1, always on the opposite side of the CM, is at $\Omega t + \pi$, which flips the sign of both components. In Cartesian components the primaries are at

$$\mathbf{r}_1(t) = r_1(-\cos\Omega t,\, -\sin\Omega t,\, 0), \qquad \mathbf{r}_2(t) = r_2(\cos\Omega t,\, \sin\Omega t,\, 0). \tag{1.3}$$

Newton's second law for M_1 fixes the rate: its acceleration is $\Omega^2 r_1$ toward the CM (uniform circular motion) and the only force on it is M_2's pull GM_1M_2/R^2, also toward the CM, so

$$\begin{aligned} M_1\Omega^2 r_1 &= \frac{GM_1M_2}{R^2} && \text{(mass} \times \text{acceleration} = \text{force)} \\ M_1\Omega^2\,\frac{M_2 R}{M_1 + M_2} &= \frac{GM_1M_2}{R^2} && (r_1 \text{ from (1.2)}) \\ \Omega^2 &= \frac{G(M_1 + M_2)}{R^3}. && \text{(cancel } M_1M_2\text{, multiply by } (M_1 + M_2)/R) \end{aligned} \tag{1.4}$$

This is Kepler's third law for the pair.

Step 2: the Lagrangian, without yet worrying about constraints. The body m has three Cartesian coordinates and (so far) no constraint. So, $\mathcal{L} = T - U$ with

$$\mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{2}m\big(\dot X^2 + \dot Y^2 + \dot Z^2\big) - U(X, Y, Z, t), \qquad U = -\frac{GmM_1}{|\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_1(t)|} - \frac{GmM_2}{|\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_2(t)|}, \tag{1.5}$$

where $|\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_i(t)| = \sqrt{(X - X_i(t))^2 + (Y - Y_i(t))^2 + Z^2}$ and (X_i, Y_i) are the components in (1.3). Lagrange's equations for X, Y and Z are Newton's second law with the two attractions: for X, $\partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\dot X = m\dot X$ and $\partial\mathcal{L}/\partial X = -\partial U/\partial X$, so $\frac{d}{dt}\partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\dot X = \partial\mathcal{L}/\partial X$ reads $m\ddot X = -\partial U/\partial X$, and likewise for Y and Z; together, $m\,\ddot{\mathbf{r}} = -\boldsymbol{\nabla}U$. Familiar ground.

To see that $-\boldsymbol{\nabla}U$ is the two attractions, write $d_i = |\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_i(t)|$ for the two distances, so that $U = -GmM_1/d_1 - GmM_2/d_2$. Then

$$\begin{aligned} -\boldsymbol{\nabla}U &= -\Big(\frac{\partial U}{\partial X}, \frac{\partial U}{\partial Y}, \frac{\partial U}{\partial Z}\Big) \\ &= GmM_1\Big(\frac{\partial}{\partial X}\frac{1}{d_1}, \frac{\partial}{\partial Y}\frac{1}{d_1}, \frac{\partial}{\partial Z}\frac{1}{d_1}\Big) + GmM_2\Big(\frac{\partial}{\partial X}\frac{1}{d_2}, \frac{\partial}{\partial Y}\frac{1}{d_2}, \frac{\partial}{\partial Z}\frac{1}{d_2}\Big) \\ &= GmM_1\,\boldsymbol{\nabla}\frac{1}{d_1} + GmM_2\,\boldsymbol{\nabla}\frac{1}{d_2}, \end{aligned}$$

so what we need are the derivatives of $1/d_1$ and $1/d_2$. Take the X derivative of $1/d_1$. Differentiating the square root $d_1 = \sqrt{(X-X_1)^2 + (Y-Y_1)^2 + Z^2}$ gives $\partial d_1/\partial X = (X - X_1)/d_1$, so by the chain rule

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial X}\frac{1}{d_1} = -\frac{1}{d_1^2}\frac{\partial d_1}{\partial X} = -\frac{X - X_1}{d_1^3};$$

the Y and Z derivatives come the same way, and we get

$$\boldsymbol{\nabla}\frac{1}{d_1} = -\frac{(X - X_1,\ Y - Y_1,\ Z)}{d_1^3} = -\frac{\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_1}{d_1^3} = \frac{\mathbf{r}_1 - \mathbf{r}}{d_1^3}.$$

Likewise, $\boldsymbol{\nabla}(1/d_2) = (\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r})/d_2^3$. So

$$-\boldsymbol{\nabla}U = GmM_1\frac{\mathbf{r}_1 - \mathbf{r}}{d_1^3} + GmM_2\frac{\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r}}{d_2^3} = \frac{GmM_1}{d_1^2}\frac{\mathbf{r}_1 - \mathbf{r}}{d_1} + \frac{GmM_2}{d_2^2}\frac{\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r}}{d_2}$$

which we can read as two forces of magnitude GmM_i/d_i^2 along the unit vectors $(\mathbf{r}_i - \mathbf{r})/d_i$ toward the primaries. Neither of Chapter 7's tests finds a conserved quantity as it stands: t appears explicitly through $\mathbf{r}_1(t)$ and $\mathbf{r}_2(t)$, so Section 7.8's $\mathcal{H}$ is not constant, and no coordinate is ignorable (Section 7.6), since U depends on all three.

Step 3: the constraints. We're holding two things fixed here. Let's look at what "held fixed" means in each case.

(i) *The motion of the primaries prescribed (fixed)* by construction. $\mathbf{r}_1(t)$ and $\mathbf{r}_2(t)$ are given functions of t, not coordinates to be varied. That sounds like cheating *and it is!* The problem is that we have to cheat. The full problem, as stated to this point, is the three-body problem. Nine coordinates, nine coupled equations of motion. Newton, Euler, Lagrange, Poincaré and many others spent, between them, two centuries working on the three-body problem. Eventually Bruns (1887) [11] and Poincaré (1890) [12] showed that it has no conserved quantities beyond the ten everyone already knew (energy, momentum, angular momentum and the center of mass), which is what a closed-form solution would need; Poincaré's memoir is also where chaos was first seen. That's cool, maybe we could get away with a series solution. Sundman (1912) [13] found one, and proved that it converges. Unfortunately, it converges terribly slowly: Belorizky estimated in 1930 [14] that reaching the accuracy of astronomical observations would take about $10^{8\,000\,000}$ terms! (Diacu [15] tells the whole story in five readable pages.) So, apart from very special cases, the three-body problem has no usable solution in closed form, and we cheat by holding something fixed.

Well, in our case, m is tiny compared to M_1 and M_2, so it's barely going to affect their motion at all. Hence, we decide to hold the motion of the primaries fixed (stealing their solution from the solvable two-body problem), while only varying the motion of m. This is called the *restricted* three-body problem.[3] We note that it's the same sort of restriction used in Example 7.6 (the bead on a spinning hoop) where the hoop's angle ωt is prescribed and only the bead's θ is a coordinate. It is a constraint on the system, not on m: it removes the six coordinates of the primaries from the problem and is what put t into U.

[3]The same approximation runs through quantum mechanics and chemistry. The hydrogen molecular ion H_2^+ with clamped nuclei is the quantum version: one light particle in the field of two heavy centers whose positions are prescribed, not solved for. There the justification is that the nuclei are slow (the Born–Oppenheimer separation of time scales); here it is that the third body's pull on the primaries is of order m/M and is dropped. One more parallel: with the rotation switched off, the classical problem is Euler's problem of two fixed centers, which is exactly solvable, just as H_2^+ separates in prolate spheroidal coordinates. What makes the rotating problem hard is the Coriolis force, the velocity-dependent term in the equations of motion (1.11) (Step 5).

(ii) *We set* $Z = 0$. This is not a constraint in Section 7.3's sense, since no wire or surface enforces it. Rather, it is two choices. The first is a choice of coordinates: the motion of our primaries is confined to a plane, and we're just choosing that to be the XY plane. The second is a choice of initial conditions for m, which the equations of motion respect. We can spell this out a bit more explicitly if you're skeptical: U is even in Z (both distances contain Z only as Z^2), so

$$\frac{\partial U}{\partial Z} = \frac{GmM_1\,Z}{|\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_1|^3} + \frac{GmM_2\,Z}{|\,\mathbf{r} - \mathbf{r}_2|^3}, \qquad \text{so on } Z = 0\text{:} \qquad \frac{\partial U}{\partial Z} = 0 \quad \text{and} \quad m\ddot{Z} = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial Z} = 0.$$

So, a body that starts in the plane with $\dot{Z} = 0$ stays in it, and we look only at those motions. What about our little mass m wanting to leave the plane? Our goal is to find the places where it sits still with respect to the primaries, and those are all in the plane: $\partial U/\partial Z$ above is Z times a positive factor, so it vanishes only at $Z = 0$, and a body held off the plane is pulled back toward it. Nothing is lost by staying in the plane.

So once the primaries are prescribed, m has three degrees of freedom; restricting to the planar motions of (ii) removes Z and does nothing to X and Y. Two generalized coordinates remain.

Step 4: the Lagrangian with the constraints in, in good coordinates. With $Z = 0$ the Lagrangian (1.5) loses its $\dot{Z}$ term and U loses Z:

$$\mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{2}m\big(\dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2\big) - U(X, Y, t) \tag{1.6}$$

and it's time to decide which two generalized coordinates to use. U only depends on t because the primaries move, so if we pick coordinates that move with the primaries, U will lose this t dependence. This may seem a bit unnatural, but Section 7.3 allows generalized coordinates whose relation to the position involves t (Example 7.6 uses one), and we opt for the rotating coordinates x and y given by

$$X = x\cos\Omega t - y\sin\Omega t, \qquad Y = x\sin\Omega t + y\cos\Omega t, \tag{1.7}$$

where (X, Y) are inertial: the (x, y) axes are the (X, Y) axes turned counterclockwise through the angle Ωt (you can write this down as a trig problem, or just use the standard rotation matrix), so a point at fixed (x, y) goes around the origin at angular speed Ω, in step with the primaries. The other way round is the rotation through $-\Omega t$,

$$x = X\cos\Omega t + Y\sin\Omega t, \qquad y = -X\sin\Omega t + Y\cos\Omega t, \tag{1.8}$$

which is the form Section 7.3 has in mind, the generalized coordinates as functions of the position and t. We will not need it: we'll build $\mathcal{L}$ by putting (1.7) into (1.6) directly, which will give us an equation in terms of x, y and t.

In these new coordinates the primaries sit at $(x, y) = (-r_1, 0)$ and $(r_2, 0)$ for all time[4] You can see this intuitively (the whole reason we choose these co-moving coordinates was to fix the motion of the primaries), or you can see it explicitly by plugging $(x, y) = (r_2, 0)$ into the rotation: $X = r_2\cos\Omega t$, $Y = r_2\sin\Omega t$, which is (1.3), and $(-r_1, 0)$ likewise gives $\mathbf{r}_1(t)$. So the U of equation (1.5), the $U(X, Y, t)$ of (1.6), becomes

$$U(x, y) = -\frac{GmM_1}{\sqrt{(x + r_1)^2 + y^2}} - \frac{GmM_2}{\sqrt{(x - r_2)^2 + y^2}}, \tag{1.9}$$

[4] In terms of the mass ratio μ of Step 1, which Nailing down details (p. 11) uses, that is $(-\mu R, 0)$ and $((1-\mu)R, 0)$.

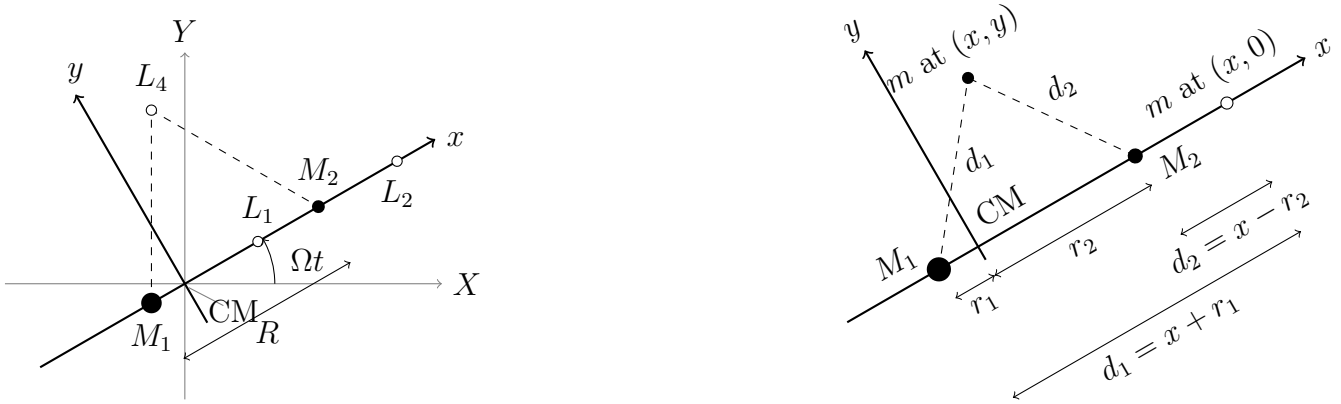


Figure 1: Left: the inertial axes (X, Y) and the rotating axes (x, y), turned through Ωt about the Z axis, which runs through the CM and out of the page. The primaries sit on the x axis. L_1, L_2 and L_4 are three of the five Lagrange points, the places where m can sit still in the rotating frame; Step 6(a) and Nailing down details find them. L_4 is the point of the dashed equilateral triangle; L_1 and L_2 are drawn where they fall for this mass ratio ($\mu = 0.2$). Right: the same picture in the rotating frame alone, where the primaries are fixed at $(-r_1, 0)$ and $(r_2, 0)$ and (1.9) is just $U = -GmM_1/d_1 - GmM_2/d_2$. For m at (x, y) the two distances are $d_1 = \sqrt{(x + r_1)^2 + y^2}$ and $d_2 = \sqrt{(x - r_2)^2 + y^2}$; for m on the axis beyond M_2 the square roots collapse to $x + r_1$ and $x - r_2$.

with no t. For the kinetic energy, we need $\dot{X}$ and $\dot{Y}$: differentiate (1.7) with the product rule (remembering that Ω is constant):

$$\dot{X} = \dot{x}\cos\Omega t - \Omega x\sin\Omega t - \dot{y}\sin\Omega t - \Omega y\cos\Omega t,$$
$$\dot{Y} = \dot{x}\sin\Omega t + \Omega x\cos\Omega t + \dot{y}\cos\Omega t - \Omega y\sin\Omega t.$$

Collect the $\cos\Omega t$ and $\sin\Omega t$ terms:

$$\dot{X} = (\dot{x} - \Omega y)\cos\Omega t - (\dot{y} + \Omega x)\sin\Omega t,$$
$$\dot{Y} = (\dot{x} - \Omega y)\sin\Omega t + (\dot{y} + \Omega x)\cos\Omega t.$$

Square and add: the cross terms $\mp 2(\dot{x} - \Omega y)(\dot{y} + \Omega x)\sin\Omega t\cos\Omega t$ cancel and $\cos^2\Omega t + \sin^2\Omega t = 1$, so

$$\dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2 = (\dot{x} - \Omega y)^2 + (\dot{y} + \Omega x)^2.$$

Expand the squares:

$$(\dot{x} - \Omega y)^2 + (\dot{y} + \Omega x)^2 = \dot{x}^2 - 2\Omega y\dot{x} + \Omega^2 y^2 + \dot{y}^2 + 2\Omega x\dot{y} + \Omega^2 x^2,$$
$$\text{so} \qquad \dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2 = \dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2 + 2\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + \Omega^2(x^2 + y^2).$$

Putting $\frac{1}{2}m$ times this into (1.6) turns

$$\begin{aligned}\mathcal{L} &= \tfrac{1}{2}m\big(\dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2\big) - U(X, Y, t)\\ &= \tfrac{1}{2}m\big(\dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2\big) + \frac{GmM_1}{\sqrt{(X - X_1(t))^2 + (Y - Y_1(t))^2}} + \frac{GmM_2}{\sqrt{(X - X_2(t))^2 + (Y - Y_2(t))^2}}\end{aligned}$$

into

$$\boxed{\mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2+\dot{y}^2) + m\Omega\,(x\dot{y}-y\dot{x}) + \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2) - U(x,y)} \tag{1.10}$$

$$\mathcal{L} = \tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2+\dot{y}^2) + m\Omega\,(x\dot{y}-y\dot{x}) + \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2) + \frac{GmM_1}{\sqrt{(x+r_1)^2+y^2}} + \frac{GmM_2}{\sqrt{(x-r_2)^2+y^2}},$$

which is (1.1). Two remarks before differentiating: First, although it has an extra term or two in the T part, (1.10) is a big win as there is no explicit t in $\mathcal{L}$! Whew. That was the point of the coordinate change. Second, the coordinates are not "natural" in Section 7.3's sense: the relation between (x,y) and (X,Y) involves t, so T is not a pure quadratic in $\dot{x},\dot{y}$ (i.e. there are two new terms, a linear $m\Omega(x\dot{y}-y\dot{x})$ and a velocity-free term $\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2)$), exactly as for the bead on the spinning hoop.

Step 5: Lagrange's equations. Not as bad as you might expect after all of that. From (1.10),

$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial\dot{x}} = m(\dot{x}-\Omega y), \qquad \frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial x} = m\Omega\dot{y} + m\Omega^2 x - \frac{\partial U}{\partial x},$$
$$\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial\dot{y}} = m(\dot{y}+\Omega x), \qquad \frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial y} = -m\Omega\dot{x} + m\Omega^2 y - \frac{\partial U}{\partial y}.$$

Remembering that Ω is constant,

$$\frac{d}{dt}\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial\dot{x}} = \frac{d}{dt}\,m(\dot{x}-\Omega y) = m\ddot{x} - m\Omega\dot{y}, \qquad \frac{d}{dt}\frac{\partial\mathcal{L}}{\partial\dot{y}} = \frac{d}{dt}\,m(\dot{y}+\Omega x) = m\ddot{y} + m\Omega\dot{x},$$

so $\frac{d}{dt}\partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\dot{q}_i = \partial\mathcal{L}/\partial q_i$ for $q_i = x$ and y read

$$m\ddot{x} - m\Omega\dot{y} = m\Omega\dot{y} + m\Omega^2 x - \frac{\partial U}{\partial x},$$
$$m\ddot{y} + m\Omega\dot{x} = -m\Omega\dot{x} + m\Omega^2 y - \frac{\partial U}{\partial y}.$$

Move the $-m\Omega\dot{y}$ and the $+m\Omega\dot{x}$ from the left to the right:

$$m\ddot{x} = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial x} + m\Omega^2 x + 2m\Omega\dot{y}, \qquad m\ddot{y} = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial y} + m\Omega^2 y - 2m\Omega\dot{x}, \tag{1.11}$$

Newton's second law with three forces. The first is gravity, $-\boldsymbol{\nabla}U$, the two pulls of Step 2 written in the rotating coordinates.

The second is a centrifugal force $m\Omega^2(x,y) = m\Omega^2\,\mathbf{r}$, one force pointing straight away from the CM, where the rotation axis (the Z axis, out of the page in Figure 1) pierces the plane, with magnitude $m\Omega^2\sqrt{x^2+y^2}$, $m\Omega^2$ times the distance from the CM. At L_1 and L_2 in Figure 1, which lie on the x axis, it points along $+x$; at L_4 it points along the line from the CM through L_4. The x equation sees its x component $m\Omega^2 x$, the y equation its y component $m\Omega^2 y$.

The third is a Coriolis force $2m\Omega(\dot{y},-\dot{x})$, perpendicular to the velocity. It depends on velocity, so it has no associated potential energy, but it does no work, since it is always perpendicular to $\dot{\mathbf{r}}$. Chapter 9 will derive both extra forces from Newton's second law in a rotating frame.[5] We see the same thing here, coming out of Lagrange's equations because the coordinates rotate.

[5] Chapter 9 writes them as $-m\,\omega\times(\omega\times\mathbf{r})$ and $-2m\,\omega\times\dot{\mathbf{r}}$ with $\omega = \Omega\hat{\mathbf{z}}$; you can check that those give the same components.

Step 6: read off results. Finally! We get two results, each basically one line of reasoning from (1.10) or (1.11).

(a) *Where can m sit still?* **(I.e. where do we want to put the JWST!)** "Sit still in the rotating frame" means $\dot{x} = \dot{y} = 0$ and $\ddot{x} = \ddot{y} = 0$. Put those into (1.11): the Coriolis terms vanish with the velocities, the left sides vanish with the accelerations, and

$$0 = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial x} + m\Omega^2 x, \qquad 0 = -\frac{\partial U}{\partial y} + m\Omega^2 y, \qquad \text{i.e.} \qquad \boldsymbol{\nabla} U_{\text{eff}} = 0, \quad U_{\text{eff}} \equiv U - \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2), \tag{1.12}$$

since $m\Omega^2 x = -\partial_x\big(-\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2)\big)$ and likewise for y. Notice the order of operations here: we set the velocities to zero in the *equations of motion*, after the variation, never in $\mathcal{L}$ itself. Here, as it happens, setting $\dot{x} = \dot{y} = 0$ in (1.1) first leaves $\mathcal{L} = -U_{\text{eff}}$ and the same condition, but that is luck, and the equations of motion are gone (no $\ddot{x}$, no Coriolis term, so no way to ask whether the point is stable). In other problems, taking the "shortcut" of setting them to zero in $\mathcal{L}$ gives wrong equations outright: e.g. if you substitute the conserved angular momentum into a central-force Lagrangian before varying, the centrifugal term comes out off by a minus sign. Another way of seeing this is that we can make a statement about the motion only after Lagrange's equations are derived; only a constraint on the *configuration* (a bead on a wire, Section 7.5) goes into the coordinates before. Figure 2 shows U_{eff} for the mass ratio $\mu = 0.1$ (an unrealistically heavy M_2, chosen so the five points separate on the page) with its five stationary points.

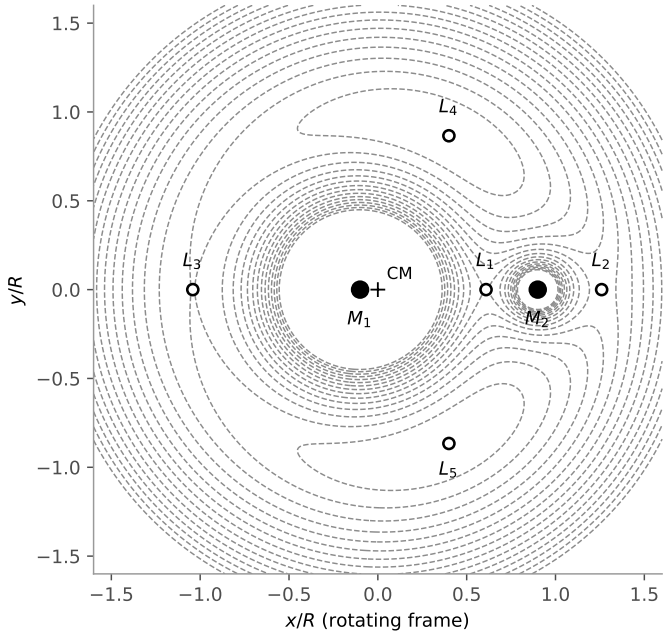


Figure 2: Contours of the effective potential U_{eff} in the rotating frame for $\mu = 0.1$, with the two primaries (filled) and the five Lagrange points (open). L_1, L_2, L_3 are saddle points; L_4 and L_5 are the two maxima. Drawn by `make_figure.py` in the handout's folder.

Now we look for solutions of $\boldsymbol{\nabla} U_{\text{eff}} = 0$. Three are on the x axis, L_1, L_2 and L_3, and they need nothing beyond (1.12): put $y = 0$, and the y equation holds by itself (every term in it carries a

factor of y), while the x equation, with $d_1 = |x + r_1|$ and $d_2 = |x - r_2|$ on the axis, becomes

$$m\Omega^2 x = \frac{GmM_1\,(x + r_1)}{|x + r_1|^3} + \frac{GmM_2\,(x - r_2)}{|x - r_2|^3}, \tag{1.13}$$

the centrifugal term on the left and two copies of Newton's law of gravitation on the right, each toward its own primary. That is one equation in the one unknown x, with three roots. In Nailing down details we solve it numerically and look at the limiting case of a small μ by expanding about M_2 (see (1.17), solved in units where $R = 1$). We find that there are exactly five solutions (this is the one place we need polar coordinates; "Polar coordinates" in Nailing down details). The remaining two, L_4 and L_5, are off axis. Figure 3 shows all five.

The two off the axis are not so tricky to derive. Take the point $\mathbf{r}$ a distance R from *both* primaries, the third corner of an equilateral triangle on M_1M_2, with $\mathbf{r}_1 = (-r_1, 0)$ and $\mathbf{r}_2 = (r_2, 0)$ in the rotating frame. Then $d_1 = d_2 = R$, and the gravity term of (1.12), divided by m, is

$$\begin{aligned}
-\frac{1}{m}\boldsymbol{\nabla} U &= \frac{GM_1(\mathbf{r}_1 - \mathbf{r})}{d_1^3} + \frac{GM_2(\mathbf{r}_2 - \mathbf{r})}{d_2^3} && \text{(the two pulls, Step 2)} \\
&= \frac{G}{R^3}\Big[(M_1\mathbf{r}_1 + M_2\mathbf{r}_2) - (M_1 + M_2)\,\mathbf{r}\Big] && (d_1 = d_2 = R) \\
&= -\frac{G(M_1 + M_2)}{R^3}\,\mathbf{r} && (M_1\mathbf{r}_1 + M_2\mathbf{r}_2 = 0\text{: origin at the CM}) \\
&= -\Omega^2\,\mathbf{r}\,. && \text{(by (1.4))}
\end{aligned} \tag{1.14}$$

The centrifugal term of (1.12) divided by m is $+\Omega^2\,\mathbf{r}$, so the two cancel and $\boldsymbol{\nabla} U_{\text{eff}} = 0$ there. Those are L_4 and L_5, 60° ahead of and behind M_2 as seen from M_1, for any mass ratio (on M_2's orbit only in the limit $\mu \to 0$). (Jupiter's Trojans and Greeks are asteroids that, in fact, orbit L_4 and L_5.)

In words: this is pretty neat. At the equilateral points the two bodies' gravity points exactly at the CM (look at Figure 3 and think about this: not at the center of the triangle's edge, or at the center of the triangle, but at the CM), with exactly the strength a circular orbit of angular speed Ω needs at that radius, so the test mass goes around the CM in step with the primaries!

(b) *What is conserved?* $\mathcal{L}$ in (1.10) has no explicit t, so by Section 7.8 the Hamiltonian $\mathcal{H} = \sum_i p_i\dot{q}_i - \mathcal{L}$ is conserved. With $p_x = \partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\dot{x} = m(\dot{x} - \Omega y)$ and $p_y = \partial\mathcal{L}/\partial\dot{y} = m(\dot{y} + \Omega x)$,

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathcal{H} &= m(\dot{x} - \Omega y)\dot{x} + m(\dot{y} + \Omega x)\dot{y} - \mathcal{L} = m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) + m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) - \mathcal{L} \\
&= m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) + m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) \\
&\qquad - \Big[\tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) + m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2 + y^2) - U\Big] \\
&= \tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) + U_{\text{eff}}(x, y),
\end{aligned} \tag{1.15}$$

the last line by subtracting (1.10) term by term: the $m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x})$ cancel, half of $m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2)$ survives, and $-\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2 + y^2) + U$ is U_{eff}. This is the Jacobi integral (celestial mechanics usually quotes $C_J = -2\mathcal{H}/m$). Three remarks, the first two of which are the point of Section 7.8:

(a) It is conserved, and it looks like an energy: kinetic energy in the rotating frame plus the effective potential.

(b) It is *not* $T + U$. The true kinetic energy is $\frac{1}{2}m(\dot{X}^2 + \dot{Y}^2)$, and from Step 4 it is $\frac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2 + \dot{y}^2) +$

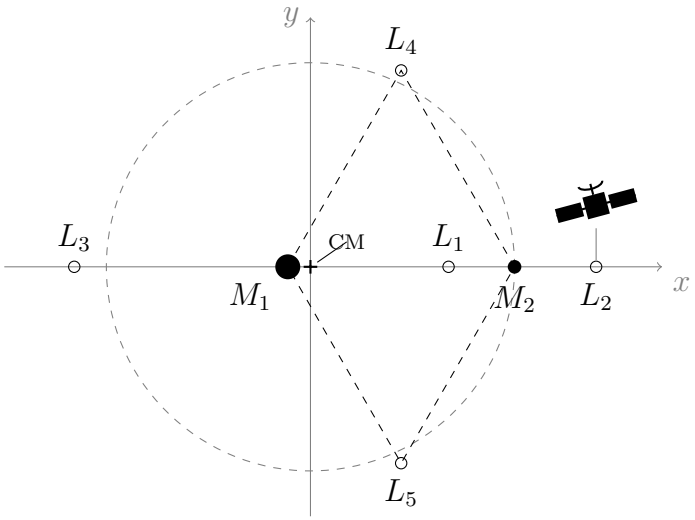


Figure 3: The five Lagrange points in the rotating frame, drawn to scale for $\mu = M_2/(M_1+M_2) = 0.1$ (the mass ratio of Figure 2; for the Sun and the Earth, L_1 and L_2 sit one percent of R from the Earth and would not separate on the page). L_1, L_2, L_3 on the line of the primaries, found from (1.17); L_4, L_5 at the third corners of the two equilateral triangles (dashed) on M_1M_2. The dashed circle is M_2's orbit about the CM. The satellite marks L_2: for the Sun and the Earth that is where JWST sits, beyond the Earth on the far side from the Sun (SOHO sits at L_1); the Trojan asteroids are at L_4 and L_5. L_1, L_2, L_3 are saddles of U_{eff} and unstable for every mass ratio, which is why JWST needs station-keeping; L_4, L_5 are maxima of U_{eff}, yet stable for $\mu < 0.0385$ ("Stability" in Nailing down details), which is why the Trojans and Greeks stay put.

$m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + \frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2)$; adding U and subtracting (1.15),

$$T + U - \mathcal{H} = \left[\tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2+\dot{y}^2) + m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2) + U\right] - \left[\tfrac{1}{2}m(\dot{x}^2+\dot{y}^2) + U - \tfrac{1}{2}m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2)\right] = m\Omega(x\dot{y} - y\dot{x}) + m\Omega^2(x^2+y^2), \tag{1.16}$$

which is not constant: in polar coordinates ($x = r\cos\theta$, $y = r\sin\theta$, so $x\dot{y} - y\dot{x} = r^2\dot{\theta}$ and $x^2+y^2 = r^2$) it is $m\Omega r^2\dot{\theta} + m\Omega^2 r^2 = \Omega\, mr^2(\dot{\theta}+\Omega)$, Ω times m's angular momentum about the CM in the inertial frame (whose angular velocity is $\dot{\theta}+\Omega$), and the primaries' pull is not aimed at the CM, so it exerts a torque. Taylor's condition for $\mathcal{H} = T+U$ (Section 7.8, pp. 269–272) was that the relation between the generalized coordinates and the inertial position not involve t; (1.7) involves t, so the condition fails, exactly as for the spinning hoop. (And $T+U$ is not conserved in the inertial frame either: there the primaries move and U depends on time. The symmetry lives in the rotating frame, and so does the conservation law.)[6]

(c) Since $\frac{1}{2}mv_{\text{rot}}^2 \geq 0$, a body with a given $\mathcal{H}$ can only be where $U_{\text{eff}} \leq \mathcal{H}$. The contours in Figure 2 are therefore fences (Hill's *zero-velocity curves*): a satellite with $\mathcal{H}$ below $U_{\text{eff}}(L_1)$ that starts near M_2 can never leave M_2's neighborhood, however it moves. Raising $\mathcal{H}$ past $U_{\text{eff}}(L_1)$ opens a gate to M_1; past $U_{\text{eff}}(L_2)$, a gate to the outside.

And we are done! In Nailing down details, we add the Hill radius, an argument that there are

[6] We note that this is subtle, and often interpreted incorrectly, even in published articles.

exactly five Lagrange points, a calculation of where exactly those points are, and we address the stability of the points.

Nailing down details

Board problem: L_1 and L_2 for a small μ. Use units with $R = 1$ and $G(M_1 + M_2) = 1$, so $\Omega = 1$ by (1.4), $M_1 \to 1 - \mu$ at $x = -\mu$ and $M_2 \to \mu$ at $x = 1 - \mu$. In these units the axis equation (1.13), per unit mass, is

$$x = \frac{(1-\mu)(x+\mu)}{|x+\mu|^3} + \frac{\mu\,(x-1+\mu)}{|x-1+\mu|^3}. \tag{1.17}$$

Show that for $\mu \ll 1$ both L_1 and L_2 sit a distance

$$d \approx R\left(\frac{\mu}{3}\right)^{1/3} \tag{1.18}$$

from M_2, one on each side, and evaluate it for the Sun and the Earth ($\mu = 3.00 \times 10^{-6}$, $R = 1.496 \times 10^8$ km). This d is called the *Hill radius*; inside it M_2's gravity wins over M_1's tidal pull plus the centrifugal force (the -2δ and the $+\delta$ in the solution below). The Moon, at 3.84×10^5 km, sits well inside the Earth's Hill radius of 1.5×10^6 km, which is why it is the Earth's moon and not the Sun's.

Solution. Take L_2 first. It lies just beyond M_2, so write $x = 1 - \mu + \delta$ with a small $\delta > 0$; then $x + \mu = 1 + \delta$ and $x - 1 + \mu = \delta$. The three terms of (1.17), one at a time, each expanded to first order in δ:

$$\begin{aligned}
x &= 1 - \mu + \delta && \text{(left side: centrifugal term per unit mass, } \Omega = 1\text{)} \\
\frac{(1-\mu)(x+\mu)}{|x+\mu|^3} &= \frac{1-\mu}{(1+\delta)^2} && \text{(right, first term: } M_1\text{'s pull)} \\
&\approx (1-\mu)(1-2\delta) && \text{(binomial expansion, } (1+\delta)^{-2} \approx 1 - 2\delta\text{)} \\
&\approx 1 - \mu - 2\delta && \text{(drop } 2\mu\delta\text{, small compared to } 2\delta\text{)} \\
\frac{\mu\,(x-1+\mu)}{|x-1+\mu|^3} &= \frac{\mu\,\delta}{\delta^3} = \frac{\mu}{\delta^2} && \text{(right, second term: } M_2\text{'s pull, exact)}
\end{aligned}$$

Now, put it together:

$$\begin{aligned}
1 - \mu + \delta &= 1 - \mu - 2\delta + \frac{\mu}{\delta^2} && \text{(by (1.17))} \\
\delta &= -2\delta + \frac{\mu}{\delta^2} && \text{(the } 1 - \mu \text{ terms cancel)} \\
3\delta &= \frac{\mu}{\delta^2} \\
\delta^3 &= \frac{\mu}{3}.
\end{aligned}$$

The orders are consistent: $\delta = (\mu/3)^{1/3}$ is much larger than μ, so the dropped $\mu\delta$ and δ^2 are small compared to δ, while μ/δ^2 is the same size as δ.

For L_1, just inside M_2, write $x = 1 - \mu - \delta$ with $\delta > 0$, so $x + \mu = 1 - \delta$ and $x - 1 + \mu = -\delta$. The same three terms become

$$\begin{aligned} x &= 1 - \mu - \delta && \text{(centrifugal)} \\ \frac{1-\mu}{(1-\delta)^2} &\approx 1 - \mu + 2\delta && (M_1\text{'s pull; } (1-\delta)^{-2} \approx 1 + 2\delta) \\ \frac{\mu\,(-\delta)}{\delta^3} &= -\frac{\mu}{\delta^2} && (M_2\text{'s pull, now toward } +x) \end{aligned}$$

and assembling them,

$$\begin{aligned} -\delta &= 2\delta - \frac{\mu}{\delta^2} && \text{(by (1.17), the } 1-\mu \text{ terms cancel)} \\ \delta^3 &= \frac{\mu}{3}. \end{aligned}$$

Every term changed sign, so to this order L_1 and L_2 are mirror images about M_2, at the same distance δ.

Restoring R, $d = \delta R = R(\mu/3)^{1/3}$, which is (1.18). For the Sun and the Earth, $(\mu/3)^{1/3} = (1.00 \times 10^{-6})^{1/3} = 0.0100$, so $d = 0.0100 \times 1.496 \times 10^8$ km $= 1.50 \times 10^6$ km, about four times the Moon's distance.

JWST orbits around L_2, on a "halo orbit" a few hundred thousand km across, so the Sun, the Earth and the Moon are always on the same side of it, behind its sunshield. □

The exact positions. Equation (1.17) is a quintic once the absolute values are resolved, so the three collinear points are found numerically. There is exactly one in each of the intervals below: for f in the code (left side of (1.17) minus right side), $f'(x) = 1 + 2(1-\mu)/|x+\mu|^3 + 2\mu/|x-1+\mu|^3 > 0$, and f runs from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$ across each interval. Solving it with `scipy.optimize.brentq` on the three intervals (left of M_1, between, right of M_2):

	μ	L_1: inside M_2	L_2: beyond M_2	d from (1.18)	L_3, x/R
Sun–Earth	3.00×10^{-6}	1.49×10^6 km	1.50×10^6 km	1.50×10^6 km	-1.000001
Sun–Jupiter	9.54×10^{-4}	5.19×10^7 km	5.43×10^7 km	5.31×10^7 km	-1.0004
Earth–Moon	1.22×10^{-2}	5.80×10^4 km	6.45×10^4 km	6.13×10^4 km	-1.005

The approximation (1.18) is good to about a third of a percent for the Earth and to about five percent for the Moon, whose μ is not so small (the next term in the expansion is of relative size $\mp\frac{1}{3}(\mu/3)^{1/3}$). L_3 sits on the far side of M_1, essentially on M_2's orbit. The code is a few lines:

```
from scipy.optimize import brentq
def f(x, mu):
    return x - (1-mu)*(x+mu)/abs(x+mu)**3 - mu*(x-1+mu)/abs(x-1+mu)**3
mu = 3.003e-6
L3 = brentq(f, -2.0, -mu-1e-9, args=(mu,))
L1 = brentq(f, -mu+1e-9, 1-mu-1e-9, args=(mu,))
L2 = brentq(f, 1-mu+1e-9, 2.5, args=(mu,))
```

Why are there exactly five points? Put the test mass at (r, θ) from the CM, with θ measured from the CM-to-M_2 line, so the distances to the primaries are $r_1' = \sqrt{r^2 + 2rr_1\cos\theta + r_1^2}$ and $r_2' =$

$\sqrt{r^2 - 2rr_2\cos\theta + r_2^2}$ (law of cosines; M_1 is at angle π, M_2 at angle 0) with $r_1 = \mu R$, $r_2 = (1-\mu)R$. The centrifugal term depends on r alone, so the θ half of (1.12) is $\partial U/\partial\theta = 0$. Differentiate $r_1'^2 = r^2 + 2rr_1\cos\theta + r_1^2$ with respect to θ, and $r_2'^2$ likewise:

$$2r_1'\frac{\partial r_1'}{\partial\theta} = -2rr_1\sin\theta, \qquad \frac{\partial r_1'}{\partial\theta} = -\frac{rr_1\sin\theta}{r_1'},$$
$$2r_2'\frac{\partial r_2'}{\partial\theta} = +2rr_2\sin\theta, \qquad \frac{\partial r_2'}{\partial\theta} = +\frac{rr_2\sin\theta}{r_2'}.$$

Then, with $U = -GmM_1/r_1' - GmM_2/r_2'$,

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial U}{\partial\theta} &= \frac{GmM_1}{r_1'^2}\frac{\partial r_1'}{\partial\theta} + \frac{GmM_2}{r_2'^2}\frac{\partial r_2'}{\partial\theta} && \text{(chain rule)}\\ &= -\frac{GmM_1\,rr_1\sin\theta}{r_1'^3} + \frac{GmM_2\,rr_2\sin\theta}{r_2'^3}\\ &= Gm\,r\,M_1r_1\sin\theta\left(\frac{1}{r_2'^3} - \frac{1}{r_1'^3}\right) = 0. && (M_1r_1 = M_2r_2\text{, the CM condition of Step 1}) \quad (1.19)\end{aligned}$$

So every equilibrium has $\sin\theta = 0$ (on the axis: L_1, L_2, L_3, one in each of the three stretches the primaries cut the axis into, as "The exact positions" above shows) or $r_1' = r_2'$ (on the perpendicular bisector of the primaries: L_4, L_5), and nothing else. On the bisector $r_1' = r_2' \equiv s$, and the algebra of Step 6(a) goes through with R replaced by s: gravity per unit mass is $-G(M_1+M_2)\,\mathbf{r}\,/s^3$, pointing at the CM, against the centrifugal $+\Omega^2\,\mathbf{r} = +G(M_1+M_2)\,\mathbf{r}\,/R^3$. So the r half of (1.12) holds only at $s = R$, the equilateral point. This factorization is the quickest way to see that there are exactly five points.[7]

Stability. Figure 2 shows L_1, L_2, L_3 as saddles of U_{eff} and L_4, L_5 as maxima. In fact U_{eff} has no minimum anywhere. Work per unit mass in the units of the board problem ($R = 1$, $G(M_1+M_2) = 1$, $\Omega = 1$), so that

$$U_{\text{eff}} = -\frac{1-\mu}{d_1} - \frac{\mu}{d_2} - \frac{x^2+y^2}{2}, \qquad d_1 = \sqrt{(x+\mu)^2+y^2}, \quad d_2 = \sqrt{(x-1+\mu)^2+y^2}. \qquad (1.20)$$

To see this, we will need the second derivatives of one gravitational term, $-M/d$ with $d = \sqrt{(x-a)^2+y^2}$ the distance to a mass M at $(a,0)$:

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(-\frac{M}{d}\right) &= \frac{M}{d^2}\frac{\partial d}{\partial x} = \frac{M(x-a)}{d^3} && (\partial d/\partial x = (x-a)/d)\\ \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x^2}\left(-\frac{M}{d}\right) &= \frac{M}{d^3} - \frac{3M(x-a)^2}{d^5} && \text{(product rule)}\\ \frac{\partial^2}{\partial y^2}\left(-\frac{M}{d}\right) &= \frac{M}{d^3} - \frac{3My^2}{d^5}\\ \frac{\partial^2}{\partial x\,\partial y}\left(-\frac{M}{d}\right) &= -\frac{3M(x-a)\,y}{d^5}. && (1.21)\end{aligned}$$

Add the first two: $2M/d^3 - 3M\big[(x-a)^2+y^2\big]/d^5 = 2M/d^3 - 3M/d^3 = -M/d^3$. The centrifugal term contributes -1 to each. So, everywhere in the plane,

$$\frac{\partial^2 U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2 U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial y^2} = -\frac{1-\mu}{d_1^3} - \frac{\mu}{d_2^3} - 2 < 0\,: \qquad (1.22)$$

[7] It is how Edlund [21] organizes the whole problem.

at least one of the two curvatures is negative at every point, so U_{eff} curves downward in some direction everywhere, and no point is a minimum. For a static potential that would be the end of the story: the small-oscillation analysis of Taylor's Example 7.7 calls an equilibrium stable only at a minimum, and would declare all five points unstable. However, the fact that we addressed the problem via a rotating coordinate frame is a hint that we need to dig a bit more. The key is to ask what the Coriolis force, which we dropped in Step 6(a) by setting the velocities to zero, does to a body that has started to move.

Beyond here, it gets a bit technical. We've put in the full details, but readers may well want to skip past this box if their eyes begin to glaze over.

Linearizing with the Coriolis term kept. Per unit mass and in these units, with gravity and the centrifugal force combined into U_{eff} as in (1.12), the equations of motion (1.11) are

$$\ddot{x} = -\frac{\partial U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial x} + 2\dot{y}, \qquad \ddot{y} = -\frac{\partial U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial y} - 2\dot{x}. \tag{1.23}$$

Put the body near an equilibrium, $x = L_x + \xi$, $y = L_y + \eta$ with ξ, η small, and expand the force to first order. At the equilibrium the first derivatives vanish, so with

$$A \equiv \frac{\partial^2 U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial x^2}, \qquad B \equiv \frac{\partial^2 U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial x\,\partial y}, \qquad C \equiv \frac{\partial^2 U_{\text{eff}}}{\partial y^2} \qquad \text{(all evaluated at the equilibrium)}$$

we have $\partial U_{\text{eff}}/\partial x \approx A\xi + B\eta$ and $\partial U_{\text{eff}}/\partial y \approx B\xi + C\eta$, and (1.23) becomes

$$\ddot{\xi} - 2\dot{\eta} = -A\xi - B\eta, \qquad \ddot{\eta} + 2\dot{\xi} = -B\xi - C\eta. \tag{1.24}$$

These are linear with constant coefficients, so we try $\xi = ae^{\lambda t}$, $\eta = be^{\lambda t}$:

$$\begin{aligned} &(\lambda^2 + A)\,a + (B - 2\lambda)\,b = 0 && \text{(the } \xi \text{ equation, divided by } e^{\lambda t}\text{)} \\ &(B + 2\lambda)\,a + (\lambda^2 + C)\,b = 0. && \text{(the } \eta \text{ equation)} \end{aligned} \tag{1.25}$$

A solution with a, b not both zero needs the determinant to vanish:

$$\begin{aligned} 0 &= (\lambda^2 + A)(\lambda^2 + C) - (B - 2\lambda)(B + 2\lambda) \\ &= \lambda^4 + (A + C)\lambda^2 + AC - B^2 + 4\lambda^2 \\ &= \lambda^4 + (4 + A + C)\,\lambda^2 + (AC - B^2). \end{aligned} \tag{1.26}$$

This is a quadratic in $\Lambda \equiv \lambda^2$. The roots come in pairs $\pm\lambda$, so if any λ has a positive real part some mode grows like $e^{(\operatorname{Re}\lambda)t}$ and the point is unstable. (The pairing also means a decaying root always has a growing partner: without friction there is no damping.) Nothing grows only if every λ is purely imaginary, $\lambda = \pm i\omega$, which means both roots Λ of

$$\Lambda^2 + (4 + A + C)\,\Lambda + (AC - B^2) = 0 \tag{1.27}$$

are real and negative. For a quadratic that is three conditions on the coefficients:

$$\begin{aligned} AC - B^2 &> 0 && \text{(the product of the roots is positive)} \\ 4 + A + C &> 0 && \text{(their sum is negative)} \\ (4 + A + C)^2 &> 4(AC - B^2). && \text{(the roots are real)} \end{aligned} \tag{1.28}$$

Now compare with the static problem. Dropping the Coriolis terms $2\dot{\eta}$ and $2\dot{\xi}$ from (1.24) deletes the $4\lambda^2$ in (1.26), and the conditions become $AC - B^2 > 0$ and $A + C > 0$: both curvatures positive, a minimum, Taylor's result (the third condition then holds automatically). The *entire* effect of the Coriolis force on the linear problem is the 4 in the λ^2 coefficient. That 4 cannot help a saddle: at a saddle $AC - B^2 < 0$, so one root Λ is positive, one λ is real and positive, and the body leaves. It can help a maximum: there $AC - B^2 > 0$ and $A + C < 0$, but $4 + A + C$ can still be positive, and if the third condition also holds every mode oscillates. So a maximum of U_{eff} really can be a stable equilibrium.

L_1, L_2, L_3: saddles, unstable for every μ. On the axis $y = 0$, so $d = |x - a|$ in (1.21), and the second derivatives of each gravitational term simplify to $-2M/d^3$, M/d^3 and 0. Writing

$$\kappa \equiv \frac{1-\mu}{d_1^3} + \frac{\mu}{d_2^3} \qquad \text{(evaluated at the point, } d_1 = |x+\mu|,\ d_2 = |x-1+\mu|\text{)} \tag{1.29}$$

for the sum of the two M/d^3's, and adding the centrifugal -1's,

$$A = -2\kappa - 1, \qquad B = 0, \qquad C = \kappa - 1. \tag{1.30}$$

A is negative. C is positive because $\kappa > 1$ at all three points, which follows from the axis equation (1.17) itself:

$$\kappa x - x = \frac{(1-\mu)\big[x - (x+\mu)\big]}{d_1^3} + \frac{\mu\big[x - (x-1+\mu)\big]}{d_2^3} \qquad (\kappa x \text{ from (1.29)},\ x \text{ from (1.17)})$$

$$(\kappa - 1)\, x = \mu(1-\mu)\Big(\frac{1}{d_2^3} - \frac{1}{d_1^3}\Big). \tag{1.31}$$

At L_1 and L_2, $x > 0$ and the point is nearer M_2 than M_1 ($d_2 < d_1$), so the right side is positive and $\kappa > 1$. At L_3, $x < 0$ and $d_1 < d_2$, so both sides are negative and again $\kappa > 1$. Hence $A < 0 < C$: each collinear point is a saddle of U_{eff}, as Figure 2 shows, and

$$AC - B^2 = -(2\kappa + 1)(\kappa - 1) < 0$$

fails the first condition in (1.28) for every μ. Explicitly, with $4 + A + C = 2 - \kappa$, (1.27) is $\Lambda^2 + (2-\kappa)\Lambda - (2\kappa+1)(\kappa-1) = 0$,

$$\Lambda_\pm = \frac{(\kappa-2) \pm \sqrt{(\kappa-2)^2 + 4(2\kappa+1)(\kappa-1)}}{2} = \frac{(\kappa-2) \pm \sqrt{9\kappa^2 - 8\kappa}}{2}, \tag{1.32}$$

one positive and one negative: one pair of modes $e^{\pm\lambda t}$ with real $\lambda = \sqrt{\Lambda_+}$, one pair of oscillations with $\omega = \sqrt{-\Lambda_-}$. Any displacement with a component along the growing mode leaves on the timescale $1/\lambda$.

The numbers for the Sun–Earth L_2: $d_1 = 1.0100$, $d_2 = 0.01004$ (the table above), so $\kappa = 0.9705 + 2.970 = 3.94$, $\Lambda_+ = 6.17$, $\lambda = 2.48$ and $\omega = 2.06$. The unit of time is $1/\Omega$, the orbital period over 2π: $365.25/2\pi = 58.1$ days. So a displacement from L_2 grows by a factor e every $58.1/2.48 = 23$ days, and the oscillatory pair has period $2\pi/2.06 \times 58.1 = 178$ days. That is JWST: it rides the oscillatory mode on a halo orbit of period about six months, and every three weeks or so fires its thrusters to cancel what has leaked into the growing mode. (For small μ the result is universal: at L_1 and L_2, $d_2 = \delta$ with $\delta^3 = \mu/3$ from (1.18), so $\kappa \approx 1 + \mu/\delta^3 = 4$,

and $\lambda \approx 2.5$ whatever the masses. For the Earth–Moon L_2, $\kappa = 3.19$ and the e-folding time is two days.)

L_4, L_5: maxima, stable for $\mu < 0.0385$. At $L_4 = (\frac{1}{2} - \mu, \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2})$ both distances are 1, with $x - a_1 = x + \mu = \frac{1}{2}$, $x - a_2 = x - 1 + \mu = -\frac{1}{2}$ and $y^2 = \frac{3}{4}$. Put those into (1.21) with $d = 1$, add the two masses (they total 1) and the centrifugal -1's:

$$\begin{aligned} A &= (1-\mu)\big(1 - 3\cdot\tfrac{1}{4}\big) + \mu\big(1 - 3\cdot\tfrac{1}{4}\big) - 1 = \tfrac{1}{4} - 1 = -\tfrac{3}{4} \\ C &= (1-\mu)\big(1 - 3\cdot\tfrac{3}{4}\big) + \mu\big(1 - 3\cdot\tfrac{3}{4}\big) - 1 = -\tfrac{5}{4} - 1 = -\tfrac{9}{4} \\ B &= -3(1-\mu)\big(\tfrac{1}{2}\big)\big(\tfrac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\big) - 3\mu\big(-\tfrac{1}{2}\big)\big(\tfrac{\sqrt{3}}{2}\big) = -\frac{3\sqrt{3}}{4}\,(1-2\mu). \end{aligned} \tag{1.33}$$

(L_5 has $y \to -y$, which flips the sign of B and changes nothing below, since only B^2 enters.) Then

$$\begin{aligned} AC - B^2 &= \frac{27}{16} - \frac{27}{16}(1-2\mu)^2 \\ &= \frac{27}{16}\big(4\mu - 4\mu^2\big) = \frac{27}{4}\,\mu(1-\mu) > 0, \qquad (1-(1-2\mu)^2 = 4\mu - 4\mu^2) \end{aligned} \tag{1.34}$$

and $A + C = -3 < 0$ (which is (1.22) with $d_1 = d_2 = 1$): both curvatures negative, a maximum of U_{eff}, as Figure 2 shows. Without the Coriolis term (1.27) would be $\Lambda^2 - 3\Lambda + \frac{27}{4}\mu(1-\mu) = 0$, whose roots are both positive (sum 3, product positive): two real growing modes, Taylor's verdict. With it, $4 + A + C = 1$,

$$\Lambda^2 + \Lambda + \frac{27}{4}\,\mu(1-\mu) = 0, \qquad \Lambda_\pm = \frac{-1 \pm \sqrt{1 - 27\mu(1-\mu)}}{2}. \tag{1.35}$$

The sum of the roots is -1 and their product is positive, so the first two conditions in (1.28) hold for every μ; the third is that the square root be real:

$$27\mu(1-\mu) < 1 \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad \mu < \frac{1 - \sqrt{23/27}}{2} = 0.0385. \tag{1.36}$$

Below that mass ratio both Λ's are real and negative, every mode oscillates, and L_4 and L_5 are (linearly) stable; above it the Λ's are complex, every λ has a nonzero real part, and they are not (Pluto–Charon, with $\mu = 0.11$, has no stable Trojan points). This is Gascheau's result of 1843 [17].[a] The two frequencies are $\omega_\pm = \sqrt{-\Lambda_\pm}$:

	μ	$27\mu(1-\mu)$	long period, $2\pi/\omega_+$	short period, $2\pi/\omega_-$
Earth–Moon	1.22×10^{-2}	0.324	21.1 time units = 92 days	6.6 time units = 29 days
Sun–Jupiter	9.54×10^{-4}	0.0257	78 time units = 147 yr	6.3 time units = 11.9 yr

The short period is always close to the orbital period (2π time units): that mode is nearly the epicycle a free body makes when seen from the rotating frame. The long one is the *libration* around L_4, and in fact the Trojan and Greek asteroids are observed to follow the 147-year period seen in the table.

[a] Linear stability is the whole story here except at two resonant mass ratios inside the interval, $\mu = 0.0135$ and 0.0243, where the two frequencies are in a 3:1 or 2:1 ratio and the nonlinear terms take over (Deprit and Deprit-Bartholomé [19]); Murray and Dermott [2], Chapter 3, cover the linear analysis and the history.

What the Coriolis force is doing. In most problems that we encounter, a body stays in a region because that region is an energy minimum. That's not what's going on at L_4 or L_5. It can't be, because both are *maxima* not minima! What on earth?! Let's dig in. The Jacobi constant (1.15) gives $\frac{1}{2}v^2 = E - U_{\text{eff}}$, and near a maximum every neighboring point has a *lower* U_{eff}, so every neighboring point is allowed, at a higher speed; conservation of energy forbids nothing. What happens instead is that the body starts down the hill, the Coriolis force $2(\dot{y}, -\dot{x})$ turns the growing velocity sideways, and the body is swung around L_4 rather than away from it, like a charged particle in a magnetic field (the Coriolis term has exactly the form of $q\,\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{B}$ with $\mathbf{B}$ along z). The slow mode is that circulation. It is a wide one: a body released from rest a distance ϵ from the Earth–Moon L_4 wanders, according to (1.24), out to between 16ϵ and 28ϵ depending on the direction of the initial displacement, and for Sun–Jupiter to between 40ϵ and 70ϵ. "Stable" here means "stays in a neighborhood of L_4, forever," not "returns to L_4," and the neighborhood is large; the real Trojans and Greeks librate on tadpole-shaped paths that span tens of degrees of Jupiter's orbit. This kind of stability, by a velocity-dependent force that does no work, is called *gyroscopic*, and Greenberg and Davis [20] is a short, readable account. It is also fragile in one specific way: add any friction, however small, and a body at a potential maximum eventually does fall off (a theorem of Thomson and Tait, 1879 [22]). The same velocity-coupled linear equations (1.24), with the Earth's rotation supplying the $2\dot{\eta}$ and $2\dot{\xi}$, describe Chapter 9's Foucault pendulum.

References

A note on the references. Most of the pointers below were found through Wikipedia, and I am a bad scholar who has not necessarily followed up to verify each and every one. For example, I have not read any of (Bruns, Poincaré, Sundman, Belorizky, Gascheau, Thomson and Tait) because they're hard to track down. Available texts are in the handout's `references/` folder.

Reference	Wikipedia article that cites it	Notes
Belorizky [14], and the $10^{8\,000\,000}$ figure	Three-body problem [6]	
Barrow-Green [16]	Three-body problem [6]	
Diacu [15]	Three-body problem [6]; n-body problem [7]	
Sundman [13]	n-body problem [7]	
Poincaré [12]	Chaos theory [9]	
Bruns [11]	Heinrich Bruns [8]	Wikipedia lists the 1887 Leipzig version, not the Acta Mathematica reprint we cite
Gascheau [17], Sicardy [18]	Point de Lagrange [10]	French Wikipedia article translated to English by Claude
Murray and Dermott [2]	Jacobi integral [5]	
Goldstein [3], Peebles [4]		We just checked the table of contents
Deprit [19]		Sicardy quoted it and we trusted Sicardy
Greenberg and Davis [20]		Just read the abstract
Edlund [21]		Text in the GitHub repo
Thomson and Tait [22]		Text in the GitHub repo (from archive.org, the 1912 reprint)
Kirillov and Verhulst [23]		Text in the GitHub repo (from arXiv)

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